CINEMA

THE HEAT IS ON

THE COMPETITION SECTIONS AT THE UPCOMING KOLKATA INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL PROMISE A TREASURE TROVE OF INTERESTING FILMS

The 29th edition of the Kolkata International Film Festival, to be held between December 5 and 12, is featuring multiple competitive sections for national and international feature-length films, short films, and documentaries.

Leading the roster is the International Competition section. Carlos Daniel Malavé's Venezuelan film *One Way* is an immigration drama tracking a mother caught in a social and economic crisis. Globalisation is also the theme of Spanish actor-turned-filmmaker Liz Lobato's debut directorial project *Land of Our Mothers*, a farcical look at a village slowly getting sold away while its inhabitants prefer to look the other way to keep the community intact. Meanwhile, Asa Helga Hjorleifsdottir's Icelandic film *A Letter From Helga* is in sombre contrast and follows a scandalous affair between a farmer and his poet neighbour in a village in the 1940s.

The only Indian film in this section is Anjan Dutt's Bengali production, *Chalchitra Ekhon*, in which the musician-filmmaker celebrates his mentor Mrinal Sen's birth centenary. The master filmmaker, who died in 2018, had given Dutt his earliest lead roles in films like *Kharij* and *Chalchitra*.

In the Indian Language-competition section, there is Lubdhak Chatterjee's *Whispers of Fire and Water*, in which an audio installation artist visiting a major mining zone in eastern India goes through a process of self-discovery. Manipuri filmmaker Haobam Paban Kumar's *Joseph's Son* has a father setting out in search of his son who hasn't returned home in a conflict-afflicted state. Manoj Shinde's *Valli* follows a man who abandons the Jogta custom, in which a cisgendered man has to embody femininity, and escapes to the city.

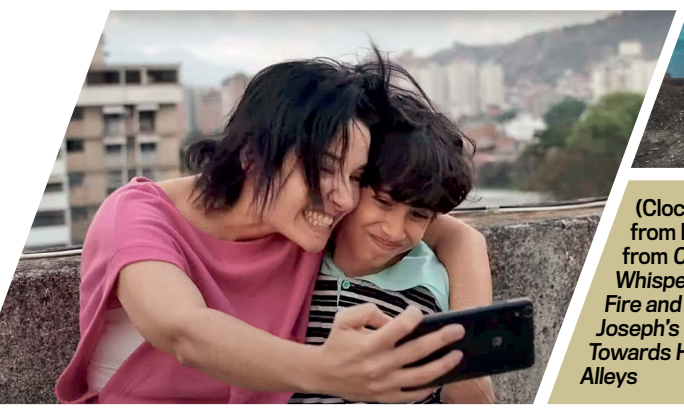
In contention for the sought-after Network for the Promotion of Asian Cinema's (NETPAC) top award is Sreemoyee Singh's *And Towards Happy Alleys*, which had been in the making for six years. Inspired by Iranian filmmakers' struggles, Singh travelled to Tehran to collect interviews with activists, women, and director Jafar Panahi, who has been banned from making films, giving interviews, or leaving the country. The film is a document of how daily living is an act of revolution in Iranian society.

Also in competition is *Broken Dreams: Stories from the Myanmar Coup*, an anthology film by Ninefold Mosaic, a group of exiled filmmakers from Myanmar. The film tracks stories of ordinary Myanmarese citizens caught in a military-governed country.

Bindu Nair's *Forged in Fire*, which tracks several individuals who are fighting or have survived cancer, as well as their families, is among the highlights of the competitive Indian Documentary section. Haider Khan's *Langur* takes a look at the life of 29-year-old Jacky Wadhwani, who has dedicated his life to taking care of langur monkeys. Khan was inspired to make the film when he encountered the Gujarat-born Wadhwani, roaming the streets painted and dressed as a monkey, the director's statement says.

Moving to local contests, seven Bengali films from upcoming directors will be competing for the top prize in the Bengali Panorama section. The films include Rajdeep Paul and Sarmistha Maiti's *Mon Potongo*; Abhijit Sridas's *Bijoyar Pore*; Rajdeep Ghosh's *Bonbibi*; Amartya Sinha's *Asampurno*; Rajesh Roy's *Matripaksha*; Debapratim Dasgupta's *Abar Ashbo Phirey*; and Anisul's *Awnath*. ■

Devarsi Ghosh









(Clockwise from left) stills from *One Way*, *Whispers of Fire and Water*, *Joseph's Son*, *And Towards Happy Alleys*